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| <b>Texas WIC</b><br><b>Health and Human Services Commission</b> |
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Effective: November 1, 2025

Policy No. CS: 24.0

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## **Certification Periods**

### **Purpose**

To identify the length of time program participants are eligible for WIC benefits.

### **Authority**

7 CFR Part 246.7; 26 TAC §366.7

### **Policy**

Program benefits will be provided to participants based on certification timeframes as outlined in this policy for each category.

### **Definitions**

Certification period is the timeframe established for each category.

Certification end date is the last day of the certification period and the last day the participant will receive benefits.

Extension/Shortening of the Certification End Date – to extend or shorten the certification end date by 1 month. Examples include: (1) shortening an infant’s certification end date to align with sibling’s (child) recertification or (2) extending a child’s certification end date to include the month the child turns 5 years old.

### **Procedures**

- I. Certification periods begin on the date the applicant is determined eligible for benefits.
- II. A pregnant woman is certified to receive benefits for the duration of her pregnancy, and until the last day of the month in which her infant turns six weeks or the pregnancy ends.

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Example:

|                               |          |
|-------------------------------|----------|
| Expected delivery date:       | 06/04/yy |
| Date infant is six weeks old: | 07/16/yy |
| Certification end date:       | 07/31/yy |

The benefits issued between delivery and six weeks postpartum may be issued before OR at the time of the postpartum screening.

III. A postpartum woman who is not breastfeeding is certified until the last day of the month that her infant turns six months or the pregnancy ends.

Example:

|                                |          |
|--------------------------------|----------|
| Delivery date:                 | 06/04/yy |
| Date infant is six months old: | 12/04/yy |
| Certification end date:        | 12/31/yy |

IV. A breastfeeding woman (fully, partially, or some breastfeeding) is certified up to the last day of the month the infant turns 1-year or until the woman discontinues breastfeeding, whichever comes first. See [BF:01.0 Breastfeeding Promotion and Support Standards](#) for definition of breastfeeding woman.

Example:

|                              |          |
|------------------------------|----------|
| Delivery date:               | 06/04/yy |
| Day infant turns 1-year-old: | 06/04/yy |
| Certification End date:      | 06/30/yy |

A. If a woman discontinues breastfeeding **before** six months postpartum her category, risk conditions (if applicable) and food package must be changed in the MIS to reflect the postpartum category and continue to receive benefits. If her eligibility was based solely on breastfeeding risk conditions, risk code 501,

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Regression, may be applicable based on her pregnancy risk conditions. If risk code 501 is not applicable, staff must assign risk code 401, Failure to Meet Dietary Guidelines for Americans, and the woman must be issued postpartum benefits.

- B. If a woman discontinues breastfeeding **after** six months postpartum, she is no longer categorically eligible. Staff must void the benefits or place a lock on the Texas WIC card, and her certification must be terminated (see [CS:23.0 Notification of Ineligibility, Disqualification, Termination or Expiration of Eligibility](#)) in the MIS.

- V. A child, up to age 5, is certified for a 12-month period ending on the last day of the twelfth month. If needed, the certification end date may be extended/shortened for one month.

Example:

|                          |          |
|--------------------------|----------|
| Certification start date | 12/14/yy |
| Certification end date:  | 11/30/yy |

Eligibility for a child turning five years of age will expire at the end of the month in which the child reaches their fifth birthday.

Example:

|                         |          |
|-------------------------|----------|
| Child's fifth birthday: | 03/19/yy |
| Certification end date: | 03/31/yy |

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If a child is certified in the month of their fifth birthday, the certification must be completed before the birth date for the child to be eligible for benefits. This includes initial and subsequent certifications.

Example:

|                         |          |
|-------------------------|----------|
| Child's fifth birthday: | 03/19/yy |
| Date of Certification:  | 03/11/yy |
| Certification end date: | 03/31/yy |

VI. An infant, younger than six months at the time of initial enrollment, is certified up to their first birthday. Certification end date is the day prior to the infant's first birthday. If needed, the certification end date may be extended/shortened for one month.

Example:

|                         |          |
|-------------------------|----------|
| Date of birth:          | 11/22/yy |
| Certification end date: | 11/21/yy |

VII. An infant, six months or older at the time of initial enrollment, is certified for a six-month period ending on the last day of the sixth month. If needed, the certification end date may be extended/shortened for one month.

Example:

|                           |          |
|---------------------------|----------|
| Date of birth:            | 11/22/yy |
| Certification start date: | 07/11/yy |
| Certification end date:   | 12/31/yy |